

Word family: **serve / serves / served / serving / service / server / servant**

Base word: serve

Forms: serves, served, serving

Related forms: service, server, servant

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun in sports through **serve** (名詞 , 體育) / related nouns (相關名詞)

Your sentence:

> “Besides **serving meals**, they are increasingly being used for lengthy activities...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **serve** means **to provide food or drink to customers, guests, or diners**.

繁體中文： **供應；端上；為顧客提供食物或飲品**

中文翻譯：

> “Besides **serving meals**...”

「除了**供應餐點 / 為顧客提供膳食**之外.....」

Here:

serve meals = 把食物準備好並提供給顧客 / 用餐者

1. **serve = provide food or drink (餐飲) — 供應；端上；招待**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: To provide food or drink for someone to eat or drink.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The restaurant **serves** meals throughout the day.”

「這間餐廳全天**供應餐點**。」

Practice 2

> “Breakfast is **served** from seven o'clock.”

「早餐由七時開始**供應**。」

Practice 3

> “They **served** coffee after dinner.”

「晚餐後，他們**端上 / 提供**咖啡。」

****serve food/drink = 把食物或飲品提供給別人享用****

Common:

- * serve breakfast
- * serve dinner
- * serve drinks
- * serve customers
- * serve food hot

2. ****serve = provide a service/help to people or a group (服務) — 服務；為……提供所需****

****Serve** can mean working for the benefit of a person, community, customer group, or population.**

Practice 4

> “The hospital **serves** the local community.”

「這間醫院為本地社區**提供服務**。」

Practice 5

> “The company **serves** customers across Asia.”

「這家公司為亞洲各地的顧客**提供服務**。」

****serve someone/group = 為某人或某群體提供所需服務、協助或資源****

Common:

- * serve the public
- * serve customers
- * serve the community
- * serve local residents

This is a major broader extension of the food-service sense.

3. **serve = work/do official duty for an organization, country, leader, etc. (任職 / 效力) — 任職 ; 服務 ; 效力**

Serve can mean performing duties for an institution, government, military, organization, or person.

Practice 6

> “She **served** in the army for six years.”

「她在軍隊**服役**六年。」

Practice 7

> “He **served** as mayor for two terms.”

「他曾擔任市長兩個任期。」

Practice 8

> “She **served** on the committee.”

「她曾在該委員會**任職 / 擔任委員**。」

****serve = 在某個機構、職位或正式角色中履行職責****

Common:

- * serve in the military
- * serve in government
- * serve on a committee
- * serve under someone
- * serve as chairperson

4. **serve as = function as / be used as (用途) — 充當 ; 作為 ; 起.....作用**

This is one of the most important constructions.

Practice 9

> “The room also **serves as** a meeting space.”

「這個房間也**用作 / 充當**會議空間。」

Practice 10

> “The wall **serves as** a screen.”

「這面牆**充當**屏幕使用。」

****serve as something = 具有某種功能、用途或角色****

This is especially relevant to your passage conceptually:

> eateries becoming classrooms

The restaurant is being used to ****serve as**** something it was not primarily designed to be.

5. ****serve = fulfil a purpose / be useful for something (用途) 一起作用 ; 達到目的 ; 滿足需要****

****Serve**** can mean being useful or helping accomplish a purpose.

Practice 11

> “The warning ****serves**** an important purpose.”

「這個警告**發揮了重要作用**。」

Practice 12

> “This example ****serves**** to illustrate the problem.”

「這個例子**用來說明**問題。」

****serve a purpose / serve to do something = 發揮某種作用、達到某個目的****

Common:

- * serve a purpose
- * serve a function
- * serve a need
- * serve to illustrate
- * serve to remind

This is closely related to ****serve as****, but important enough to teach separately.

6. ****serve** = be suitable or sufficient for a need (夠用) — 可用 ; 足以應付******

Sometimes ****serve**** means that something is adequate for a particular purpose.

Practice 13

> “This small table will ****serve**** for now.”

「這張小桌子目前暫時****夠用****。」

Practice 14

> “A simple explanation should ****serve****.”

「簡單的解釋應該就****足夠了****。」

****serve** = 足以滿足某種暫時或實際需要******

For strict counting, I would merge this into Meaning 5.

7. ****serve** = spend a prison sentence (法律) — 服刑******

A major legal use:

Practice 15

> “He ****served**** five years in prison.”

「他在監獄****服刑****五年。」

Practice 16

> “She is currently ****serving**** a life sentence.”

「她目前正在****服無期徒刑****。」

****serve a sentence / serve time** = 接受並完成法院判處的監禁期******

This is a genuinely distinct legal sense.

8. **serve = formally deliver legal documents (法律) — 送達 ; 正式交付法律文件**

Another important legal sense:

Practice 17

> “The papers were **served** on the defendant.”

「文件已正式**送達**被告。」

Practice 18

> “He was **served** with a court summons.”

「他收到正式**送達的法院傳票**。」

serve someone with legal documents = 按法律程序正式把文件送交當事人

Common:

* serve a summons

* serve notice

* serve legal papers

* be served with documents

This should definitely remain separate from ordinary “provide service.”

9. **serve = begin play by hitting/throwing the ball (體育) — 發球**

In sports such as tennis, volleyball, badminton, table tennis, etc., **serve** means to begin a point by putting the ball/shuttle into play.

Practice 19

> “She **served** first.”

「她先**發球**。」

Practice 20

> “He **served** the ball into the corner.”

「他把球**發到**角落。」

****serve = 在球類運動中以規定方式把球 / 球體發出，開始一個回合****

This is a major distinct sense.

10. ****a serve = act of serving the ball (體育名詞) — 發球****

As a noun:

Practice 21

> “He has a powerful ****serve****.”

「他的****發球****很有力。」

Practice 22

> “Her first ****serve**** went out.”

「她的第一次****發球****出界了。」

****a serve = 一次發球 / 發球方式****

This is the noun counterpart of Meaning 9.

11. ****serve = provide data/resources over a network (電腦) — 提供；傳送****

In computing, a system can ****serve**** data, files, pages, or requests to other computers/users.

Practice 23

> “The application ****serves**** web pages to users.”

「這個應用程式向使用者****提供 / 傳送****網頁。」

Practice 24

> “The system can ****serve**** thousands of requests.”

「這個系統可以****處理並提供****數千個請求。」

****serve = 透過網絡向其他裝置 / 使用者提供資料或資源****

For strict counting, this is a technical extension of Meaning 2:

> provide something to a recipient.

12. **serve = provide a religious duty / serve God (宗教) — 侍奉 ; 事奉**

Practice 25

> “He devoted his life to **serving** God.”

「他把一生奉獻給**事奉**上帝。」

serve = 出於宗教信仰而奉獻、服事或履行宗教責任

This is an established use but somewhat domain-specific.

Conceptually, it aligns with Meaning 3: duty/service.

13. **serve = treat someone in a particular way / give them what they deserve (固定表達) **

This gives us the very common expression:

serve someone right — 活該 ; 罪有應得

Practice 26

> “It **serves** him right for ignoring the warning.”

「他不理會警告，現在這樣真是**活該**。」

Practice 27

> “It would serve them right if they lost the money.”

「如果他們把錢弄丟，那也是**自作自受**。」

it serves someone right = 某人因自己的錯誤行為而得到應得的不良後果

This is a fixed idiom rather than a separate core meaning.

14. **serve notice = formally inform (固定正式用法) — 正式通知**

Practice 28

> “The company **served notice** that the agreement would end.”

「公司正式**通知**協議將終止。」

This can overlap with the legal-document sense but is useful enough to note explicitly.

15. **serve up = provide food / figuratively present something (片語) **

Literally:

> “They served up lunch.”

「他們端上午餐。」

Figuratively:

> “The article serves up the same old arguments.”

「這篇文章又端出那些老掉牙的論點。」

Because this is a phrasal verb and not required by the target sentence, I would keep it outside the base-word core.

Related form: **serving**

Serving has several common noun/adjective uses.

**serving = amount of food for one person (一份食物) **

Practice 29

> “One **serving** contains 200 calories.”

「一**份**含有二百卡路里。」

serving = 通常供一人食用的一份食物

**serving = currently working in a role (現任 / 服役中的) **

> “serving officers”

「現役 / 現任人員」

This is more formal and derived directly from the duty sense.

Related form: **server**

Server has several important meanings.

**server = waiter / person who serves food (服務員) **

Especially in North American English:

> “Our server brought the drinks.”

「我們的**餐廳服務員**端來飲品。」

**server = computer/system providing network resources (伺服器) **

Practice 30

> “The website is stored on a secure **server**.”

「網站儲存在安全的**伺服器**上。」

This is one of the most important modern lexical-family meanings.

Related form: **service**

Service has developed a large polysemy network of its own, including:

- * service to customers
- * public service
- * repair/maintenance
- * religious service

- * military service
- * tennis service/serve
- * computer/network service

Because it is highly polysemous independently, **service** deserves its own full entry if targeted later rather than being compressed here.

Related form: **servant**

A **servant** traditionally means a person employed to perform domestic duties for someone.

Practice 31

> “The household employed several servants.”

「那個家庭僱用了幾名**僕人 / 傭人**。」

Modern everyday usage varies by context, and more specific job titles are often preferred.

Important distinction: **serve vs provide**

provide

means make something available.

serve

often emphasizes providing it **to people/users/customers** or fulfilling a function.

> provide information

> serve customers

They overlap in many service contexts.

Important distinction: **serve vs service**

serve

is normally the verb:

> serve customers

service

as a verb often means maintain/repair equipment:

> service a car

So:

> “The restaurant services customers” ❌ usually unnatural for ordinary hospitality

Use:

> “The restaurant serves customers.” ✅

Important distinction: **serve vs attend to**

serve

often means provide customers with goods/food/service.

attend to

means deal with someone’s needs or a particular matter.

> serve a customer

> attend to a customer’s complaint

Important distinction: **serve vs work**

work for

simply means be employed by.

serve

often adds:

* duty

* public responsibility

* commitment

* official role

> work for the government

> serve in government

The latter sounds more duty-oriented.

Important distinction: **serve vs function**

In:

> serve as

the meaning is often close to:

> function as

Compare:

> “The table serves as a desk.”

> “The table functions as a desk.”

Both mean it performs that role, but **serve as** is more everyday.

Important distinction: **serve vs supply**

supply

emphasizes providing a quantity/resource.

serve

emphasizes providing to a recipient or meeting a need.

> supply electricity

> serve a population

Grammar note: **serve someone something**

Natural:

> “They served us coffee.”

Also:

> “They served coffee to us.”

Both work.

Grammar note: ****serve as + role/function****

> serve as a classroom

> serve as a reminder

> serve as evidence

> serve as chair

This is one of the word’s highest-value constructions.

Grammar note: ****serve on / serve in / serve under****

****serve on****

> serve on a committee

****serve in****

> serve in the army

> serve in government

****serve under****

> serve under a commander

These prepositions reflect different duty relationships.

Countability note

****Serve**** is mainly a verb.

As the sports noun:

> a serve

> several serves

****Serving**** as a food portion is also countable:

> one serving

> two servings

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* ****serve****

* ****served****

* ****serving****

* ****server****

* ****service****

* ****servant****

The second-pass sweep is important here because ****serve**** spreads across hospitality, public service, official duty, function/purpose, criminal sentencing, legal procedure, sport, religion, and computing.

However, many contexts still share broader concepts and should be merged after the sweep rather than being counted separately merely because the domain changes.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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serve — food/drink	把食物或飲品提供給顧客、客人或用餐者
serve — people/community	為某人、顧客或群體提供服務、協助或所需資源
serve — duty/role	在軍隊、政府、委員會、機構等履行正式職責 / 效力
serve as	充當某種角色、具有某種用途或功能
serve a purpose/need	發揮某種作用、達到目的或滿足需要
serve a sentence/time	按法院判決服刑
serve legal documents	按法律程序正式送達傳票、通知等文件
serve — sport	在球類運動中發球，開始一個回合
a serve — sport noun	一次發球 / 發球方式
serve — computing	透過網絡向使用者 / 系統提供資料或資源
serve — religion	事奉神明 / 履行宗教服務
serve someone right	某人因自己的行為得到應有後果；活該

serving — food	一人份 / 一份食物	
server	餐廳服務員；亦指提供網絡資源的伺服器	

For your original sentence

> “Besides ****serving meals****, they are increasingly being used for lengthy activities...”

The exact meaning is:

****serve = 餐廳把準備好的食物提供給顧客享用****

So:

> ****serve meals****

= ****供應餐點 / 為顧客提供膳食****

The sentence contrasts the restaurant's ordinary intended function—

> ****serving meals****

with its emerging unofficial function—

> ****being used as a classroom/tutorial venue****

For your database, I would count ****7** genuinely useful core meanings for **`serve`****:

1. ****provide food/drink****
2. ****provide service/help/resources to people or a community****
3. ****perform duty/work in an official role****
4. ****function as / fulfil a purpose or need****
5. ****serve a prison sentence****
6. ****legally deliver documents****
7. ****sport: put the ball/shuttle into play****

I would treat computing as a domain extension of #2, religious service under #3, merge ****serve as / serve a purpose / this will serve**** under the broader function branch where appropriate, and keep ****serve someone right**** as a fixed idiom rather than inflate the core count.